

**STUDENT SPOTLIGHT:
JESSICA OTTY**

This interview first appeared in the November 2020 National Coordinating Center Newsletter.

What is your name, where are you from, and what college are you attending?

My name is Jessica Otty and I am from Las Vegas, Nevada. I am currently [attending] Utah State University in Logan, Utah. I am currently a sophomore.

What classes are you taking, and which is your favorite?

The classes I am taking are Career Related Social Skills, Internship Seminar, Orientation To Elementary Education, Family Finance, and Social and Ballroom Dance. My favorite class is probably ballroom because I enjoy dancing and it is just a fun class!

What do you like to do when you're not attending class?

I am currently working which is what I enjoy doing when I am not in class.

What's good about college? (Like, what positive effects does it have on your life?)

The positive effect is that it gave me lifelong friends that I will keep forever. It also gives me a chance to get a degree in what I am interested in. I am interested in Elementary Education.

What do you hope to do after college, when you graduate or get your certificate?

I hope to teach elementary school after I graduate college. After I get my certificate, I am planning on coming back to Utah State University and finishing my degree.

What advice do you have for students with disabilities who want to go to college?

I would say that it is possible for everyone because everyone can achieve. I would tell the students that it's going to be hard at first, but it will get easier. It is okay to be homesick because everyone gets homesick.

What about parents of students of students with disabilities, do you have advice for them?

I would tell them that they [they = their children] have to be independent and learn to live on their own.



Jessica Otty



It is okay to be homesick because everyone gets homesick.

—Jess' advice to students living on campus

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If you or someone you know would like to be interviewed, contact sheila.johnson@umb.edu for more information.



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Utah State University: AGGIES ELEVATED

Aggies Elevated launched at Utah State University in the Fall of 2014 and is designed to make the college experience accessible for students with intellectual disabilities, with an end goal of meaningful employment. They provide the opportunity for students to become life-long learners by attending classes for credit with their typical peers, enjoy the long-lasting friendships that form in college, and to prepare for a career in a field that is suited to the student's interests and abilities. [Click here to visit the program's website.](#)



Thanks to Jess for her time and willingness to share a bit about her college experience!

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